Typesetting is the composition of text by arranging physical type or digital equivalents. The stored letters and other symbols are retrieved and ordered according to a language's orthography for visual display. Typesetting requires the prior process of designing a font face.

During much of the letterpress era, movable type was composed by hand. Each page was assembled letter by letter from cases of metal sorts, then locked into a forme before inking. The compositor worked from a printed or handwritten manuscript, reading backward text.

COL-ONE-END marks the end of the first column here.

COL-TWO-START opens the middle column of this three column page. Hot metal typesetting accelerated composition in the late nineteenth century. The Linotype cast whole lines as single slugs, and the Monotype machine cast individual characters under keyboard control. Both systems transformed newspaper and book production.

Phototypesetting replaced metal with light-sensitive film in the mid twentieth century. Characters were projected through glass matrices onto photographic paper, allowing easy scaling and a far wider range of shapes than cast metal allowed.

COL-TWO-END marks the end of the second column here.

COL-THREE-START opens the final column. Desktop publishing brought typesetting to personal computers in the nineteen eighties. Page description languages such as PostScript described pages as vector graphics, and fonts became mathematical outlines rather than physical sorts. The craft of spacing and justification survived the transition largely unchanged.

Digital systems then added automated hyphenation, kerning, and justification algorithms that rival or exceed hand composition. The TeX engine and its descendants remain the reference for mathematical and technical documents worldwide.